DOWNTOWN

Sunday
October 11, 2026
THE HINDU

TAMBARAM

Chromepet » Pallavaram » Tambaram West » Rajakilpakkam » Mannivakkam » Guindy » Keelkattalai » Nanganallur » Guduvanchery » Hasthinapuram » Pammal » Tambaram East

Medavakkam » Srinivasa Nagar » Kathipara Junction » Kovilambakkam » Sadasivam Nagar » Potheri » Selaiyur » Sembakkam » St.Thomas Mount » Madipakkam » Urappakkam » Paranur



RESIDENTS SEEK PROBE INTO COLLAPSE OF PEEPAL TREE

Activists suspect possible human intervention; residents cite damage to roots during drain work **P5**



WOMEN RECEIVE 'GOLDEN WINGS'

Care Earth Trust is training local women in Vedanthangal and Unamancheri to lead nature walks and earn a livelihood while spreading biodiversity awareness **P6**

Periya Eri: deploy lifeguards, place warning boards

Recently, four school students drowned in the waterbody, which has drawn demands for safety measures



T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Following the death of four children in suspected drowning in Thiruneermalai lake recently, many residents have sought additional safety measures around the waterbody.

The office bearers of the Federation of Residents' Welfare Associations in Thiruneermalai (Ward 31 of Tambaram City Municipal Corporation) have requested the Water Resources Department (WRD) to take measures to ensure the safety of visitors to this lake.

As the other three entries to the sprawling waterbody are not easily accessible from Chromepet, near Maduravoyal Bypass Road and from Madras Export Processing Zone, the children are said to have entered it from Erikarai Salai near Durga Nagar, Tambaram Sanatorium.

B. Saravanan, a resident and the treasurer of the Federation, says, "WRD should build steps to access the bund area from Thiruneermalai Main Road (near Vembarasu Vinayagar Temple). The bund is more than 15 feet high. Walkers are forced to climb an uneven, stoned, slippery path and could slide down (*see images*)."

Earlier, steps were present along the lake bund, Thiruneermalai Main Road, but are missing now.

A security guard must be deployed.

Saravanan suggests that lake wardens and lifeguards should be deployed to prevent children and youngsters from entering the lake.

Signage boards and a sound system must be installed on the bunds, stating and announcing that the water-holding area is deep, sludgy, and uneven. School children must be taught to swim and also sensitised to the dangers of visiting waterbodies alone without parental presence.

WRD should block sewage discharge into the lake, as water hyacinths have started sprouting again due to discharge from homes in the lake area, which can spoil the restoration project carried out at a cost of ₹5.15 crores.







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Residents seek probe into collapse of peepal tree

Activists suspect possible human intervention; residents cite damage to roots during drain work

T. ARVIND

Residents and green activists have sought an inquiry into the sudden collapse of a decades-old peepal tree (Ficus religiosa) behind Muthumariamman temple at the Nemilichery Main Road-Ramaswamy Cross Street junction in Bharathipuram, Chromepet. The tree fell a few days ago despite there being no rain or strong winds at the time.

People for the People's Movement general secretary and green activist Karthik Kannan suspects that the tree could have been damaged deliberately, but said the matter needed to be investigated. He said some people might have considered the tree obstructing their "view" of nearby places.

According to Kannan, when he visited the spot along with members of Pasumai Thayagam and other activists, they noticed traces of powders and chemicals near the tree's roots. He said the tree had provided shade to residents and served as a habitat for birds.

"The tree appears to have lost its support after its roots were cut. We have sought an inquiry to establish whether it fell naturally or whether there was any human intervention," he said.



The peepal tree that collapsed behind the Muthumariamman temple in Bharathipuram, Chromepet, on October 5, 2026.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Scores of residents, including women, paid their "last respects" to the tree on October 5. "Apart from the green cover, a tree adds an emotional and spiritual connect to the people of this land," said Parvathi, a resident of the locality.

Kannan has submitted a complaint to the Chief Minister's special cell and the Tahsildar, seeking an inquiry and requesting that samples found near the tree be collected and sent for laboratory testing.

However, some local residents said the tree might have lost its support after its roots were inadvertently damaged when workers dug up the area for a stormwater drain.

A nearby trader said electricity department workers had also been pruning branches of trees in the vicinity that posed a threat to transformers and overhead cables ahead of the monsoon. "As far as any miscreant angle to the tree's collapse is concerned, we are not sure," he said.

Green activists, however, said the incident highlighted the need for greater care in protecting mature trees, particularly those with ecological value. They alleged that trees were sometimes removed without adequate attention to scientific methods or due process.

Senior social activist Santhanam recalled that a 50-year-old banyan tree was removed in 2023 by the Railway and Highways authorities during the construction of the Radha Nagar subway. He said compensatory plantation norms required saplings to be planted for trees removed for development projects, but questioned whether such plantations were being properly monitored or documented.

Activists also suggested that authorities explore tree transplantation or translocation, wherever technically feasible, before deciding to remove mature trees.

Residents of Bharathipuram said their demand for an inquiry was not intended to oppose development works, but to prevent a recurrence of such incidents and promote greater awareness about protecting trees.

School rolls out the red carpet to farmers

Sri Ramana Vidyalaya Matriculation School in Tambaram lets farmers sell their organic produce from its premises every Second Sunday

LIFFY THOMAS

Every second Sunday, Sri Ramana Vidyalaya Matriculation School in Tambaram turns into a mini-market with the management opening its gates for farmers to come and sell their organic produce.

For the last three months, Thalir Karima Velaan Santhai has enabled at least 30 farmers from different villages to sell their bounty, parents of the school and neighbours being their biggest patrons.

The school management looks at this initiative as an extension of its eco-club activities where it operates a terrace garden maintained by the students.



Students at the terrace garden and during a workshop at the farmers market held at Sri Ramana Vidyalaya Matriculation School.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The garden has evolved with every passing year and currently has a good variety of vegetable growing plants. Students of classes VII to IX have one period a week allotted in their timetable to engage in terrace garden work, where they till the soil, plant saplings in used containers that serve as pots, water them and do all other things to ensure they grow.



"This time, our produce has not been great, but whatever we get is shared among students who take it home. Recently, when we got a decent amount of lady's finger and cluster beans, we left it to the students to decide who wants to take it," says V. Selvamani, correspondent of the school.

When students have a free period, they are encouraged to spend time in the terrace garden.

Traditional rice varieties, cold-pressed oils, pulses, organic gardening inputs and local pottery are among the stalls at the market.

Selvamani says they charge a nominal amount for arranging tables and chairs, and the larger goal is to eliminate middle men.

To encourage visitors to understand what goes into their plate, the organisers conduct various knowledge sharing sessions. For example, in the last few months, they had a session on tips for terrace gardening and free seed sharing, and another on making seed Ganesha using clay.

This time, there's a special workshop, "21 Plate Balanced Meal for 7 Days," from 10:30 a.m. to 12:30 p.m. by culinary artisan Akila Kunalan.

Like other farmers market happening in the city, visitors are encouraged to bring cloth bags.

For registration, call 97909 72612 or 99403 37100.

Women receive ‘Golden Wings’

An initiative by Chennai-based Care Earth Trust is training local women in Vedanthangal and Unamancheri to identify birds, lead nature walks and earn a livelihood while spreading biodiversity awareness

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Until recently, for some of the women living around Vedanthangal, the birds they saw every day were simply part of the landscape. Today, they are part of their life, even the sounds of these avians being familiar to these women’s now-trained ears. That transformation was engineered by a nature-guide training programme from Chennai-based Care Earth Trust.

With the two-fold objective of increasing biodiversity awareness and providing livelihood opportunities, the programme began with women and young people from around Vedanthangal, training them in bird identification, wetland ecology, identification of trees butterflies, and communication skills. After months of classroom lessons and practical sessions, a group of eight trained participants have come together as ‘Golden Wings’ and are now conducting guided walks at Vedanthangal.

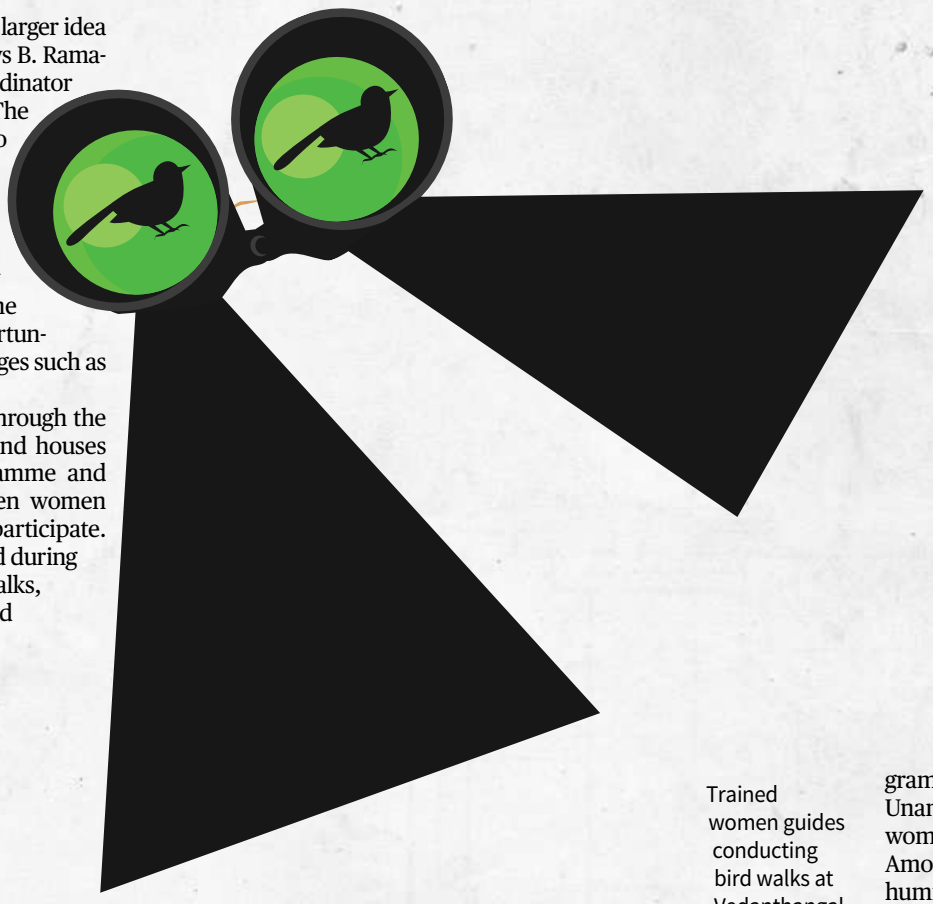
Vedanthangal resident S. Kalaiselvi Srinivasan, now a Golden Wings guide, says the work has given her an income opportunity as well as improved her communication skills.

For Subathirai D, however, the journey began with skepticism from those around her. When she first started attending the training, women in her neighbourhood questioned why she was spending her time on it. To them, learning about birds and nature seemed unnecessary, especially when she could be spending that time on household responsibilities or other work. But that perception began to change when Subathirai returned from the training and started earning through nature walks.

This is precisely the larger idea behind the project, says B. Ramamoorthy, Project Coordinator at Care Earth Trust. The organisation wanted to address two issues at once: the limited awareness among local communities about the biodiversity around them and the lack of livelihood opportunities for women in villages such as Vedanthangal.

The team worked through the panchayat, went around houses to explain the programme and spoke to families when women were hesitant to participate. Childcare was arranged during training and nature walks, food was provided, and the women themselves suggested Sundays as the most convenient day for classes.

The initial training involved classroom sessions using colour printouts and presentations to teach the participants about different birds, trees and butterflies. They then moved to practical walks, where they learnt to identify birds through their appearance and calls and understand local and native trees and their uses. They were also taken on a week-long exposure visit to Thattekad in Kerala to learn about forest biodiversity and migratory birds. The training did not stop with bird identification. The women were taught spoken English, people management and social-media skills.



Trained women guides conducting bird walks at Vedanthangal.

For Anjana Venkatesan, Programme Manager - Policy Research at Care Earth Trust, the project is about creating a connection between local women and the ecotourism circuit while drawing attention to the biodiversity outside Chennai. “Connecting them to the local kind of ecotourism circuit is a win-win for both of us,” she said. She also wants to challenge the perception that people have to travel to the Western Ghats to experience rich bird diversity. “Right in the outskirts of Chennai, you have these pockets with our existing forests and existing wetlands,” she said, adding that some of these areas record around 70 bird species during the migratory season.

The next phase of the programme is now taking shape in Unamancheri, Vandalur, where women are undergoing training. Among them is 29-year-old Madhumitha S., a B.Sc graduate who works in medical coding. Originally from Medavakkam, she moved to Unamancheri after marriage and has been attending the Sunday classes for around two months.

For Madhumitha, the training has meant discovering a side of the place she now calls home. Before joining the programme, she was familiar mainly with common birds. The classes introduced her to a much wider range of birds, trees, butterflies and other species.

Madhumitha is now learning how to handle tourists, engage them and conduct nature walks. She plans to continue her medical-coding job during the week and take up nature walks on weekends after completing her training.

‘Restore the concession for the elderly in trains’



Close to 300 members and office bearers of the Federation of Senior Citizens Associations of Tamil Nadu in Nanganallur held a peaceful demonstration on October 1 (World Elders’ Day) demanding the restoration of fare concessions for the elderly on long-distance trains.

Members gathered at Swamy Sivanandha Salai in Chepauk and urged the Central government to restore the concession, which was stopped after COVID-19.

V. Rama Rao, president of the Federation, says, “The pandemic got over in 2022. Yet the Government has not restored the concession. The All India Senior Citizens’ Confederation (AISCCON), Mumbai, the largest national apex body representing senior citizens and elderly welfare organisations in India, called for peaceful protests in public places, including railway stations, throughout the country and requested its State-level Federations to submit a petition in this regard to the District Collectors and the railway authorities.

D. Gopalakrishnan, National President, All India Bharat Sanchar Nigam Limited Pensioners Welfare Association, took part.

Earlier in the day, V. Rama Rao, M. Annadurai, president, and G. Vengovaba Rao, assistant treasurer, Probus Club, met Vipin Kumar, Additional General Manager, Southern Railway, and submitted a petition.

At the meeting, the Federation requested C. Joseph Vijay, the Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu, to constitute an elderly commission on the lines of one in Kerala State and create a separate department, as senior citizens account for nearly 1.5 crore in Tamil Nadu.

Other demands include a separate budget and fund allocation on the lines of the Kerala Assembly. Until COVID, elderly men and women enjoyed concessions of 40 and 50 percent respectively.

Challani Jewellery exhibition open today at Taj Connemara



Challani Jewellery Mart’s Challani’s Jewelverse –Season 1, a grand showcase of exquisite jewellery, commenced on October 9 at Taj Connemara, under the leadership of Jayanthilal Challani, founder and chairman of Challani Jewellery Mart.

The exhibition was inaugurated by Adityaram, founder and chairman of the Adityaram Group who formally opened the event by cutting the ribbon and lighting the traditional ceremonial lamp.

According to a press release, the exhibition brings together an extensive collection of fine jewellery, featuring gold, diamonds, Polki, rose-cut diamonds and coloured gemstones under one roof. Combining traditional craftsmanship with contemporary designs, the showcase offers visitors an opportunity to explore a diverse range of distinctive jewellery collections.

Speaking to the media after the inauguration, Adityaram expressed his appreciation for the collection on display. “I have visited several jewellery exhibitions, but the variety of collections showcased here is truly remarkable. What stands out is the range of designs available not only for women but also for men, with distinctive pieces that are visually appealing,” he said.

Jayanthilal Challani said although Challani Jewellery Mart has several branches, our objective is to bring different categories of jewellery together in one place, offering customers a comprehensive shopping experience. This exhibition features an exclusive selection of gold, diamond, Polki, rose-cut and coloured gemstone jewellery.

The inaugural event witnessed the participation of several prominent personalities, including Thangamalar Jagannath and Dr. Vimala Rani Britto, along with other distinguished guests and jewellery enthusiasts. Visitors were seen exploring the collections with considerable interest.

Challani’s Jewelverse - Season 1 is being held from October 9 to 11 (between 10:00 a.m. and 9:00 p.m.)

Venue: Taj Connemara, Binny Road, Near Spencer Plaza

Velammal Nexus felicitates Vithya Ramraj, Nehpal Singh

Velammal Nexus felicitated athlete Vithya Ramraj, who bagged three medals at the Asian Games, and her coach, Nehpal Singh.

The felicitation ceremony was hosted by Velammal Vidyalaya in Avadi.

Vithya Ramraj, her mother Meena, and Nephal Singh were welcomed with a beautifully decorated chariot procession, flower garlands, and traditional ceremonial honours, creating an atmosphere of pride and celebration across the campus.

As a mark of appreciation, Velammal Nexus presented a car each to Vithya Ramraj and Nephal Singh, said a release.

M.V. M. Velmohan, correspondent, Velammal Nexus, took part.

FORRRA writes to NPCI

The Federation of Radial Road Residents Associations (FORRRA) has urged the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) to reconsider the proposed 0.4% UPI Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on residential community / RWA maintenance collections above ₹2,000, proposed to take effect from October 15 this year. RWAs and Apartment Owners Associations operate on a non-profit, cost-recovery basis. The maintenance contributions collected from residents are used solely for essential common services such as security, water, electricity, lifts, sewage treatment, housekeeping and other community infrastructure. FORRRA has requested NPCI to create a separate category for registered RWAs / Apartment Owners Associations and extend the applicable ₹5 flat MDR – or a suitable zero/nominal MDR – to genuine non-profit maintenance collections, said a release.

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CM launches 'Dream Olympics'



Ishari K. Ganesh, president, Tamil Nadu Olympic Association, and founder-chancellor, Vels University, welcomed C. Joseph Vijay, Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu, at The Leela Palace recently.

The CM launched the 'Dream Olympics' initiative and felicitated Tamil Nadu's Asian Games and chess olympiad medal winners at the event organised by Sports Development Authority of Tamil Nadu (SDAT).

Aadhav Arjuna, State Minister for Sports Development, and prominent sportspersons were among those who took part in the event.

Charging station in Poonamallee

Zappang Charging Stations has opened an electric vehicle (EV) charging station at Motel Highway in Poonamallee.

The station features a 60 kW DC fast-charging facility, designed to provide convenient charging for EV users. Focused on clean energy and sustainable transportation, Zappang aims to make EV charging more accessible for motorists. The facility promotes a greener driving experience and encourages the transition towards environmentally friendly mobility solutions.

For location details and inquiries, contact 95666 83952.

Skincare brand embarks on expansion in Asia

International premium beauty brand Miss Universe Skincare & Spa is expanding its global presence in Asia with the appointment of Hemamalini Rajinikanth of BM Healthcare Group as Regional Director - Miss Universe Skincare Asia.

According to a press release, the appointment was announced in Chennai by Olivia Quido, CEO, Miss Universe Skincare & Spa and Vice President - Global Operations, Miss Universe, alongside Dr. Hemamalini Rajinikanth and Dr. Rajinikanth, Plastic Surgeon.

The Asian expansion follows the signing of an MOU in Los Angeles on August 26, 2026, establishing the foundation for the brand's regional development.

BM Elite International Clinic in Velachery will serve as the Asia Headquarters, supporting brand development, partnerships, franchise opportunities and market expansion.

The initiative will bring together premium Miss Universe Skincare products and professional MedSpa services under one international beauty platform, adds the press release.

Property expo in Pallavaram, Urapakkam

Today is the final day of ARK Eventz Property Expo 2026. The event is being held at Arul Murugan Towers, 200 Feet Radial Road, Old Pallavaram, and at Swapna Thirumana Mandapam, GST Road, Urapakkam; 10 a.m. to 7 p.m.

At the expo, prospective buyers can explore a wide range of property options, including apartments, villas, plots, and investment opportunities. Buyers can meet builders and developers, compare properties, and discover attractive options, said a release.

For registration and details, visit www.arkeventz. com or call 94444 56087.

Special buses to Tirumala

In view of 'Brahmotsavam' in Tirumala, the Tamil Nadu State Transport Corporation is plying 150 special buses to Tirumala from Chennai and many other places.

The passengers can book tickets on www.tnstc.in and the official app, TNSTC.

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